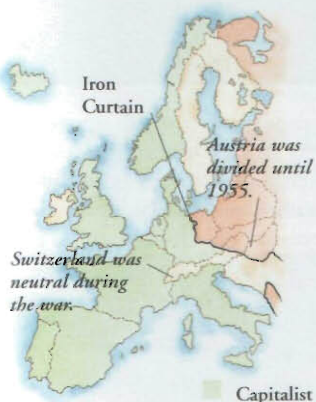


COLD WAR



IN 1945, THE ALLIED FORCES of the USA, Britain, France, and the USSR – now known once again as Russia – gained victory over Germany in World War II. Within four years, the allies had become enemies, and a new war had broken out. This was not a military war, but a “cold” war – a political and diplomatic battle between communist Eastern Europe and capitalist Western Europe. The rival blocks expressed hostility by backing opposing sides in conflicts such as Korea and Vietnam. The Cold War ended in 1990, when Eastern Europe’s communist governments fell.



Iron Curtain

By 1949, there was a clear division in Europe between the communist states in the east that followed Russia, and the capitalist states in the west that followed the USA. Both east and west became secretive and hostile. In 1946, the British Prime Minister Winston Churchill famously described this polarization as “an iron curtain ... (descending) across the continent.”



Mig-15 jet

Korean War

In 1945, Korea was divided between a communist north and an American-backed south. In 1950, North Korea invaded the south; the USA supported South Korea, while the USSR and China supported North Korea. War raged until an armistice was agreed in 1953. Korea remains divided to this day.



Winston Churchill, FD Roosevelt, and Josef Stalin, Yalta Conference

Yalta Conference

In 1945, the British, American, and Soviet leaders Churchill, Roosevelt, and Stalin met in the Russian resort of Yalta to determine the shape of post-war Europe. The conference agreed Soviet control over Eastern Europe. This started the political division of Europe into east and west that was to last until 1990.

Spies

Technological information was very important during the Cold War. In order to find out what the other side was planning, both sides of the Iron Curtain employed spies. Spies worked undercover in civilian and defence jobs, passing vital military secrets back to their own governments.

Invisible powder stuck to a spy's body and was detectable under ultraviolet light.



Chemical detection kit



Soviet ship returning to the USSR

Cuban missile crisis

In 1962 Soviet ships delivered nuclear weapons to the Cuban government. The US – only 90 miles (145 km) from Cuba – blockaded the island, which caused a crisis between the USA and the USSR. After several days of tension, the USSR withdrew its missiles.

Détente

In the 1960s, tension between east and west began to ease. In the 1970s, Willy Brandt, West Germany's leader, negotiated treaties with Poland and the USSR. In the late 1980s, Mikhail Gorbachev began to reform the USSR, which eventually led to the fall of communism in Eastern Europe.



Berlin Wall is dismantled, 1989



Anti-communist poster

Timeline

1945 Europe divides into eastern and western blocks.

1949 Western nations set up NATO (North Atlantic Treaty Organization).

1950–54 McCarthy era, USA.

1950–53 Korean War.



NATO symbol

1955 Warsaw Pact establishes military alliances between communist countries.

1961 Berlin Wall divides East from West Berlin (and East from West Germany).

1962 Cuban missile crisis marks the peak of the Cold War; its resolution slowly leads to détente.

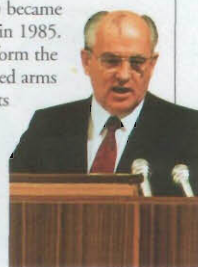
1989 Fall of the Berlin Wall begins the fall of communist governments throughout Eastern Europe.

1990 Re-unification of East and West Germany.

1991 Gorbachev resigns; collapse of communism in USSR.

Mikhail Gorbachev

Gorbachev (b.1931) became leader of the USSR in 1985. He attempted to reform the USSR, and negotiated arms reduction agreements with US President Reagan. Despite his success, he failed to improve the living standards of the Soviet people, and resigned in 1991.



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